

SIPRA DAS



FOES TURNED FRIENDS:
Sonia and Manmohan with
Amar Singh (centre)

Deal for a Deal

DELHI They're still treating it like a dirty secret but the buzz in the UPA is that the Government is slowly inching its way to ink the infamous nuclear deal with Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav saying in Kuala Lumpur recently, "I am very, very hopeful

that the deal will happen which is in India's favour."

However, of late the Left and the Congress have exchanged more than their usual share of acrimony with the communists stepping up their ante against inflation, so much so that even Sonia

Gandhi broke her diplomatic silence. While campaigning for the panchayat elections in West Bengal she attacked the Left on Nandigram as well as for its poor track of minority appeasement. This provoked the veteran Jyoti Basu to retort that Sonia's comments were meaningless. Significantly, the statement by Left leader A.B. Bardhan that

they would not topple the Government if the nuclear deal has only added to the confusion.

It is a political see-saw for the Congress. The distancing from the communists is being counter-balanced by allying with the Samajwadi Party on a common platform against Mayawati. The SP has been invited to the anniversary dinner of the UPA-Left Government at the prime minister's residence. The invite is a first after Amar Singh gate-crashed the dinner at 10 Janpath soon after the May 2004 polls. As an RSVP, he has hinted that the SP could be brought around to support the nuke deal.

All this before the scheduled UPA-Left coordination on May 28 and in the midst of the crucial Karnataka Assembly elections. This is how the ruling coalition is trying to make sense of the House.

by Priya Sahgal

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

There is a reason why India has been downplaying Pakistan's role in the recent cross-border firing and infiltration: Islamabad has indicated that it could help in the extradition of Dawood Ibrahim, India's most wanted criminal.

VOICES



"There is a case for a federal agency which will have the freedom to investigate crimes with international ramifications."

Manmohan Singh, prime minister

"I am still an unreconstructed socialist. Panchayati Raj can bring the fruits of economic reforms to the one billion Indians who are not in the Ambani family."

Mani Shankar Aiyar, minister for Panchayati Raj

"The Home Ministry asked me to round up Bangladeshis and put them in a transit camp somewhere, for which we were asked to pay."

Vasundhara Raje, Rajasthan chief minister

"Although we respect human rights and laws and want these to be applied to everyone, our tolerance and respect should not be mistaken as a soft approach towards terrorism."

P. Chidambaram, finance minister

"T20 is not cricket. A match between India and England at Lords, that's real cricket."

Jeffrey Archer, author

